Intova: what it costs to run

WhatsApp voice-note ordering for a pharmacy. Every amount is in rupees (₹). Prices checked on 21 October 2026.

One order, voice note to paid
₹1.41
Gemini (from-Jan-2027 price) + WhatsApp (after the free allowance) + server usage, before the payment fee

Payment fee on a ₹214.20 order
₹0.75
Cashfree during its offer (Razorpay: ₹5.06)

Fixed monthly cost
₹1,889
Vercel Pro; database free for a small shop

In one line: a 20-second voice note costs about **₹0.30** to understand today and **₹0.59** from 1 January 2027, when Google's price doubles (measured on your real note). WhatsApp costs nothing for your first ~142 orders a month, and the server is a flat ₹1,889 a month. Payment fees are the largest variable cost: about ₹0.75 an order with Cashfree's current offer, ₹5.06 with Razorpay.

Complete cost at a glance

What you pay for	Cost	Basis
Understanding a 20 s voice note (AI)	₹0.30 until 31 Dec 2026, ₹0.59 from 1 Jan 2027	Gemini 3.8 Flash, measured on your real voice note
WhatsApp messages	Free for about 142 orders a month, then ₹0.81 an order	7 service messages per order; first 1,000 a month are free
Server and hosting (Vercel Pro)	₹1,889 a month	Mumbai region; usage of about ₹0.012 an order sits inside Pro's included credit
Database (Neon Postgres)	₹0 on the free plan, about ₹350 a month later	Needed because Vercel cannot keep a local database file
Online payment: Cashfree	₹0.75 on a ₹214.20 order in its offer, ₹4.93 after	0.351% during the offer (first ₹20 lakh, until 31 Mar 2027), then 2.301%
Online payment: Razorpay (alternative)	₹5.06 on a ₹214.20 order	2.36% of the order
Cash on delivery	₹0	No payment provider involved
Domain name	₹0	You are using an existing domain
Tunnel (ngrok)	₹0	Not needed once deployed
Software (Next.js, Node, SQLite, ffmpeg)	₹0	Free and open source
Total at 1,000 orders a month	**₹3,972 (₹3.97 an order)**	**Gemini at its January 2027 price, Cashfree offer, 60% paid online; see section 6**

1. How the numbers were made

- **Exchange rate:** source prices were published in US dollars and converted at 1 US dollar = ₹94.43. This is the live market rate read from Google Finance in Chrome on 21 October 2026 (15:07 UTC). The rupee moves daily, so every converted figure shifts by the same percentage when it does.
- **GST:** amounts are before 18% GST unless stated. Add GST wherever your supplier invoices it (Meta and Google do for Indian businesses).
- **Example order:** 2 Dolo + 1 Dettol as in our test, value ₹214.20 including 5% GST on the medicines.
- **What is measured and what is estimated** is marked on every table.

2. Voice note cost (Gemini AI)

Each voice note is converted to MP3, sent to Google's Gemini 3.8 Flash (what your `gemini-flash-latest` setting currently points to), and answered in a fixed structure (language, transcript, medicines, quantities). You are billed for three things: the **audio** going in, the **text prompt** going in (instructions + your medicine catalog), and everything Gemini **writes back, including its internal thinking**.

Billing item (per 10 lakh tokens)	Until 31 Dec 2026	From 1 Jan 2027	Notes
Input: audio and text	₹70.82	₹141.65	One price for both. Audio measured at about 25 tokens a second (1,500 a minute); prompt and catalog are 468 tokens.
Output + thinking	₹354.11	₹708.23	Thinking tokens are billed as output and vary a lot.

Measured on real audio (Gemini's own token counts)

Voice note	Length	Audio tokens	Output + thinking	Medicines	Until 31 Dec 2026	From 1 Jan 2027
Spoken test, 1 medicine	2.6 s	67	204	1	₹0.1101	₹0.2203
Spoken test, 3 medicines	7.9 s	201	430	3	₹0.1996	₹0.3993
Your real WhatsApp voice note	20.1 s	505	642	4	₹0.2963	₹0.5925
Spoken test, 9 medicines	28.3 s	710	1,574	9	₹0.6408	₹1.2816

Even the longest clip costs under ₹1.28 from January 2027. Most of the bill is Gemini's thinking and answer, not the audio itself. The 28-second clip cost more per second because it listed 9 medicines.

Cost for a voice note of X minutes (estimate)

Voice note length (X)	Audio tokens	Typical, until 31 Dec 2026	Low, from 1 Jan 2027	Typical, from 1 Jan 2027	High, from 1 Jan 2027
15 seconds	375	₹0.2970	₹0.4558	₹0.5939	₹0.8276
30 seconds	750	₹0.5254	₹0.7745	₹1.0507	₹1.5182
1 minute	1,500	₹0.9822	₹1.4119	₹1.9643	₹2.8992
2 minutes	3,000	₹1.8958	₹2.6867	₹3.7916	₹5.6613
5 minutes	7,500	₹4.6366	₹6.5111	₹9.2732	₹13.9475

Estimate: audio at the measured 25 tokens a second, plus output (answer and thinking) of 100 + (25, 38 or 60) tokens per second spoken. "Typical" is the average of the four measurements above. Long notes that list many medicines land near "High". A 5-minute note is unusual for a pharmacy order.

The catalog is in every prompt: cost grows with stock size

Gemini is given the full medicine catalog each time so it can match names. Your test catalog has 10 medicines. A real pharmacy has hundreds or thousands, which makes the text part grow (about 22 tokens per medicine, an estimate from the 468-token measurement):

Medicines in catalog	Prompt text tokens	20 s note, until 31 Dec 2026	20 s note, from 1 Jan 2027
10	470	₹0.3732	₹0.7465
100	2,450	₹0.5135	₹1.0269
500	11,250	₹1.1367	₹2.2734
1,000	22,250	₹1.9157	₹3.8315
5,000	1,10,250	₹8.1481	₹16.2963

Watch this: at around 1,000+ medicines the per-note cost and delay both climb, and very large catalogs may stop fitting well. Before launch with a full inventory, the app should shortlist likely medicines first and send only those to Gemini. That change is not built yet.

Free vs paid: Gemini has a free tier, but for real customers use the paid tier. Google's terms say free-tier content may be used to improve its products, which is not suitable for patients' medicine orders. Check Google's current terms before launch.

Model setting: your `.env` uses `gemini-flash-latest`, an alias that Google can point at a newer model at any time, which would change both price and behaviour. Setting it to `gemini-3.8-flash` pins it. Google's page shows this model's price doubling on 1 January 2027, so the from-January column is the one to budget with.

3. WhatsApp message cost

- **Customer to you is free**, including voice notes, photos and button taps.
- Everything the app sends back is a **service message** (a reply inside the 24-hour window after the customer wrote). Since 1 October 2026 each business phone number gets **1,000 free service messages a month**. Beyond that, third-party sources quote ₹0.115 per message (Meta's utility rate). Meta's own page did not show the rupee rate, so treat ₹0.115 as likely, not certain.
- Marketing messages (offers, reminders sent outside the window) are a different category at about ₹0.86 each. Intova does not send any.

What the app sends for one order

#	Message	Billed?
-	Customer sends the voice note	Free (inbound)
1	Order confirmation card with Confirm / Change buttons	1 service message
2	Order approved, with bill total	1 service message
3	Invoice PDF	1 service message
4	Payment card (UPI or card)	1 service message*
5	Pay-on-delivery button	1 service message
6	Payment receipt	1 service message
+	New customers: language card + greeting; out-of-stock notices	1 to 3 extra
	Typical total per order (used below: 7)	**₹0.805 once past the free 1,000**

*Meta's pricing for the in-chat payment card itself is not stated on the pages I could read; I counted it as one ordinary message. Free allowance covers about 142 orders a month; after that each order adds ₹0.81. Important: Meta is moving India accounts to rupee billing and says accounts must be switched by 31 December 2026, or message delivery stops from 1 January 2027.

4. Payment cost (Cashfree or Razorpay)

Online payment is optional: customers can also pick cash on delivery, which costs nothing. For online payment you can use either provider. The app currently has Razorpay built in; Cashfree would need to be added.

Cashfree: zero platform fee on the first ₹20 lakh of sales

Item	Cost or condition
Setup fee	None
Standard rate	1.95% + 18% GST = 2.301% of the order (cards, wallets, netbanking)
Offer	Zero platform fee on up to ₹20,00,000 of domestic sales, applied automatically after KYC
GST still applies in the offer	18% GST is charged on the standard 1.95%, so the real fee is 0.351% of the order, not zero
Who qualifies	New merchants who signed up on or after 21 July 2026 and had not used Cashfree before; one offer per PAN or bank account
How long	Until 31 March 2027, or until ₹20 lakh of sales is used, whichever comes first
Not covered	Amex, Diners, corporate cards, EMI, prepaid cards, Pay Later, international cards. Cashfree can end the offer if credit cards are 60% or more of sales.
UPI	Cashfree says UPI charges are 'as per applicable law'; get the UPI rate in writing
On a ₹214.20 order paid online	**₹0.75 in the offer, ₹4.93 after**

₹20 lakh covers about 9,337 orders of ₹214.20 if all were paid online. The offer date is usually what runs out first (about 5.3 months from today), unless you do roughly 2,936 orders a month or more. One Cashfree page describes the ₹20 lakh as a monthly limit and another as a

total; I used the stricter total.

> **Trade-off:** the in-chat WhatsApp payment card (UPI or card inside the chat) only works with Razorpay, PayU, BillDesk or Zaakpay according to Meta's documentation. Cashfree is not on that list. With Cashfree, the customer taps a payment link that opens Cashfree's hosted page instead. It works, but it is one extra step away from the chat.

Razorpay

Item	Cost
Setup and yearly fees	None for a standard account
UPI, cards, netbanking, wallets (domestic)	2% + 18% GST on the fee = 2.36% of the order
Premium methods (EMI, corporate cards, Amex)	About 3% + GST
On a ₹214.20 order paid online	**₹5.06**

Razorpay's own blog is the source. Some pages mention a 0% fee for 90 days for new merchants and zero charges on plain UPI; these conflict, so I used the standard 2.36%. Confirm your rate in the dashboard. The fee is taken from the settlement; it is not billed separately.

5. Hosting on Vercel

Item	Monthly cost	Notes
Vercel Hobby	₹0	Not allowed: personal, non-commercial use only. A pharmacy business needs Pro.
Vercel Pro	₹1,889	Per developer seat. Includes a usage credit equal to the same amount that offsets function and bandwidth charges.
Function usage per order	₹0.0124	About 2 s of CPU, 12 s of 1 GB memory and 25 calls (Meta also posts delivery updates). Mumbai region.
Function usage for 3,000 orders	₹37.24	Far below the Pro credit, so effectively included
Database: Neon Postgres, Free plan	₹0	1 GB storage and 100 compute-hours; enough for a pilot
Database: Neon Launch (pay as you go)	About ₹350 (estimate)	₹10.01 per compute-hour + ₹33.05 per GB-month; no monthly minimum

Run the functions in Mumbai (bom1): CPU ₹13.22/hour and memory ₹1.095/GB-hour, close to your customers.

Four things must change before this runs on Vercel (not done yet; the app currently runs from your own computer):

- **Database.** Orders and stock live in a local SQLite file, but Vercel's disk is temporary and would lose them. They must move to a hosted database such as Neon.
- **Saved voice notes.** The app now saves each voice note to a folder on disk for debugging. That folder is not writable on Vercel; remove it or use cloud file storage.
- **ffmpeg.** The MP3 conversion needs ffmpeg, which Vercel does not provide. Bundle it as a package, or the app falls back to sending the original audio, which also works.
- **Repeat-message check.** The check that ignores repeated deliveries from Meta is held in memory and would not be shared between server instances; it should use the database.

6. Monthly total at different volumes

Assumptions: 20-second voice note per order (Gemini at its higher January 2027 price), 7 WhatsApp messages per order, 60% of orders paid online through Cashfree during its offer, average order ₹214.20.

Orders a month	Gemini	WhatsApp	Payment fee (Cashfree offer)	Vercel + database	Total	Per order
100	₹59.25	₹0.00	₹45.11	₹1,889	₹1,993	₹19.93
500	₹296.25	₹287.50	₹225.55	₹1,889	₹2,698	₹5.40
1,000	₹592.50	₹690.00	₹451.11	₹2,239	₹3,972	₹3.97
3,000	₹1,777.50	₹2,300.00	₹1,353.32	₹2,239	₹7,669	₹2.56

Orders a month	Sales value	Total cost	Cost as % of sales	Total with 18% GST on fees*
100	₹21,420	₹1,993	9.3%	₹2,344
500	₹1,07,100	₹2,698	2.5%	₹3,143
1,000	₹2,14,200	₹3,972	1.9%	₹4,606
3,000	₹6,42,600	₹7,669	1.2%	₹8,806

*GST added on Gemini, WhatsApp and hosting; the payment fees already include their GST. Hosting figures assume Vercel Pro is billed in full. At 100 orders the fixed ₹1,889 Vercel fee is almost the whole bill; AI and WhatsApp together are only a few rupees. Cash on delivery avoids payment fees entirely.

Payment fee by provider (online share 60%)

Orders a month	Online sales	Razorpay	Cashfree in offer	Cashfree after offer	Offer lasts
100	₹12,852	₹303	₹45	₹296	5.3 months
500	₹64,260	₹1,517	₹226	₹1,479	5.3 months
1,000	₹1,28,520	₹3,033	₹451	₹2,957	5.3 months
3,000	₹3,85,560	₹9,099	₹1,353	₹8,872	5.2 months

"Offer lasts" is the shorter of the 31 March 2027 deadline (about 5.3 months) and the time to use up ₹20 lakh of sales. After it ends, Cashfree (2.30%) and Razorpay (2.36%) cost almost the same.

7. Sources and how sure I am

Figure	Source	Confidence
Gemini 3.8 Flash prices (gemini-flash-latest)	ai.google.dev/gemini-api/docs/pricing	Official; one input price for audio and text
Audio tokens per second, thinking, output	Measured by running the app's code on real audio on 21 Oct 2026	Measured
WhatsApp: per-message billing, free 1,000 service messages	developers.facebook.com/docs/whatsapp/pricing	Official
WhatsApp rupee rates (₹0.115 service/utility)	Third-party blogs (dev.to, flowcall); Meta's page links a rate-card file I could not read	Likely, not verified
Razorpay 2% + GST	razorpay.com/blog pricing pages	Official blog; confirm in dashboard
Cashfree 1.95%, ₹20 lakh offer and its terms	cashfree.com/payment-gateway-charges	Official; offer terms can change, confirm at sign-up
Gateways supported by WhatsApp's payment card	Meta payments documentation (Razorpay, PayU, BillDesk, Zaakpay)	Official
Vercel Pro, regional function rates	vercel.com/pricing and vercel.com/docs/functions/usage-and-pricing	Official
Neon database prices	neon.com/pricing	Official
Dollar to rupee rate (₹94.43)	Google Finance, read live in Chrome on 21 Oct 2026, 15:07 UTC	Verified (market rate, changes daily)
Database estimate (about ₹350 a month on Neon Launch)	My estimate from Neon's per-hour and per-GB prices	Rough